6. In the Bush

A condemned man is supposed to enjoy a hearty last meal, but my dinner seemed flavourless, a nutritional necessity rather than a source of pleasure. It had nothing to do with the food at the team hotel near Tower Bridge; the palate of a struggling batsman cannot be teased, even by a kitchen staffed with Michelin-starred chefs. He is desensitized, from his taste buds to his toes.

It might almost have been a subconscious act of self-sabotage, but after the table had been cleared I sat there alone, flicking through a newspaper. Sure enough, I was being nailed as beyond my sell-by date. I had lasted only seven deliveries in the first innings of the third Test against Pakistan, and my time was assumed to be up.

It was the evening of Thursday, 19 August 2010. I was 0 not out, England were 6 for the loss of Andrew Strauss in the second innings, and I would be walking out at the Oval with Jimmy Anderson on the third morning. Things were so bad Jimmy had sacked me as his unofficial batting buddy.

As I headed for the lifts, I passed Mark Bawden, who was having a drink with a friend. Months later, he would tell me I looked as if I had the weight of the world on my shoulders. ‘You all right?’ he asked. Apparently, I smiled thinly. ‘Well, not really,’ was my deadpan response. ‘I’m about to go and play my last innings for England tomorrow.’

With that, I walked off, mentally calculating the worthiness of my international career. I had scored twelve Test centuries to that point, not bad but no protection when you can’t buy a run in a long, hot and wet summer,